

FREE HOMEOWNER GUIDE

The Bay Area Home Exterior *Care Guide*.

A season-by-season checklist for keeping your windows, gutters, and hardscape clean through Bay Area rain, pollen, and dry summers.

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simple rule for when to call a pro

Why Bay Area homes need *their own schedule*.

Most maintenance advice is written for places with snowy winters. Here, almost all the rain falls from about November through March, and the rest of the year is dry and dusty. That's why timing matters more than how often you clean.



A short, heavy rain season

Gutters need to be clear **before** the first big storm. Leaves that piled up all summer can turn into an overflow problem in a single night.



Big trees, year-round shedding

Oaks, redwoods, eucalyptus, and sycamores drop leaves, needles, and bark at different times, so homes under heavy canopy fill their gutters faster.



Spring pollen and summer dust

A yellow film shows up on glass, screens, and patios every spring. Long dry spells let dust and grime build up on everything outside.



Sprinklers and hard water

Many Bay Area cities have hard tap water. When sprinklers keep hitting the same glass, the minerals dry into white spots that get harder to remove over time.

YOUR YEAR AT A GLANCE	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
Window cleaning			●	●	●				●	●		
Gutter cleaning	●				●					●	●	
Pressure washing				●	●	●	●	●				
Soft wash siding / roof				●	●	●			●			
Storm walk-around	●	●	●								●	●

● Best time ● Good time / if needed (heavy tree cover)

What to do, *and when.*

Print this page and keep it on the fridge. Each list takes about an hour of looking around and tells you which jobs are coming up.

Fall

SEP – NOV

Most important season.
Get ready for the rain.

- ☐ **Clean gutters and downspouts** before the first big storm, usually by late October or early November.
- ☐ Run a hose into each downspout and make sure water comes out freely at the bottom.
- ☐ Check that downspouts drain at least 4 feet away from your foundation.
- ☐ **Clean windows** to wash off summer dust and smoke residue so you get clear glass for the darker months.
- ☐ Trim branches that hang over the roof so fewer leaves land on it.

Winter

DEC – FEB

Watch how the house
handles real rain.

- ☐ **Do a walk-around during or right after a storm.** Look for water spilling over gutters instead of going down the downspouts.
- ☐ Look for puddles near the foundation, splashback stains, or soil washing out under downspouts.
- ☐ If you're under heavy trees, check gutters again mid-season. One windy storm can refill them.
- ☐ Watch for green moss or algae on north-facing roofs, walls, and walkways.

Spring

MAR – MAY

Clean up after the rain
and the pollen.

- ☐ **Clean windows and screens** after the pollen peaks, when that yellow film is on everything.
- ☐ **Soft wash siding** to remove winter algae and mildew while it's still easy to lift off.
- ☐ Check gutters again if you have oaks, which drop catkins and leaves in spring.
- ☐ Check sprinkler heads and aim them away from windows and glass doors.

Summer

JUN – AUG

Dry weather. Best time
for flatwork.

- ☐ **Pressure wash driveways, walkways, and patios.** Dry weather means surfaces dry fast and stay clean longer.
- ☐ Clean the deck and outdoor furniture before you start hosting.
- ☐ Treat white hard-water spots on glass before they bake on through the summer.
- ☐ Rinse dust off screens and window tracks so they slide easily.

Windows and gutters, *the right way.*

1 Streak-free windows

- 1 **Pick shade or an overcast day.** Direct sun dries the glass before you can squeegee it, and that's what causes streaks.
- 2 Brush or vacuum dust out of the frame and track first, so you're not just moving mud around.
- 3 Mix a few drops of dish soap into a bucket of warm water. Scrub with a soft applicator or microfiber cloth.
- 4 Squeegee from top to bottom in overlapping strokes, and wipe the blade after every pass.
- 5 Dry the edges with a lint-free cloth. Skip paper towels, since they leave lint.

Hard-water spots? Soap won't remove them. Try a 50/50 mix of white vinegar and water. Let it sit a minute, then squeegee. Spots that won't come off need professional mineral removal. Don't scrape them with a razor, since you can scratch coated or tempered glass.

2 Gutters that actually drain

- 1 Use a sturdy extension ladder on firm, level ground, and have someone hold it.
- 2 **Follow the 4-to-1 rule:** for every 4 feet of height, set the base 1 foot out from the wall.
- 3 Scoop debris by hand or with a gutter scoop into a bucket. Don't push it toward the downspout.
- 4 Flush the gutter with a hose, starting at the end farthest from the downspout.
- 5 If water backs up, the downspout is clogged. Flush it from the bottom or use a plumber's snake.

Never lean a ladder against the gutter itself or stand on the top rungs. For two-story or steep homes, most people are better off hiring a crew with the right equipment.

Signs your gutters need attention now

Water pouring over the edge

The gutter or downspout is blocked, and water is landing next to your foundation.

Plants growing in the gutter

Debris has been sitting long enough to become soil.

Sagging or pulling away

Wet debris is heavy. The fasteners may be failing.

Stains on siding or fascia

Overflow is running down the walls.

Erosion under downspouts

Water isn't being carried far enough from the house.

Birds or pests nesting

Standing debris and water attract them.

Pressure wash or soft wash? *Know the difference.*

High pressure is great on concrete, but it can damage softer surfaces. Soft washing uses low pressure and a cleaning solution that does the work, so delicate materials aren't blasted.

SURFACE	METHOD	NOTES
Concrete driveways and walkways	Pressure wash	A surface-cleaner attachment gives an even, stripe-free finish. Pre-treat oil stains first.
Pavers and stone	Pressure wash (moderate)	Too much pressure can wash out joint sand. You may need to re-sand afterward.
Wood decks and fences	Soft wash / low pressure	High pressure can splinter and fur the wood grain. Let it dry fully before sealing or staining.
Stucco and painted siding	Soft wash	Pressure can chip paint and force water behind the siding.
Roofs	Soft wash only	Never pressure wash a roof. It can strip granules and shorten the roof's life.
Windows and screens	Hand wash	Pressure can break window seals, which leads to foggy glass.

Do it safely

- ☐ Wear eye protection and closed-toe shoes. A pressure washer can cut skin.
- ☐ Start with the widest nozzle and test in a hidden spot.
- ☐ Keep the wand moving and at a consistent distance to avoid streaks.
- ☐ Cover plants and nearby outlets before you start.

Mind the storm drain

Bay Area storm drains flow straight to local creeks and the Bay, without treatment. Most cities only allow rainwater to go down them.

- ☐ Rinse with plain water when you can.
- ☐ Send soapy or dirty wash water onto lawn or gravel instead of into the street.
- ☐ Sweep up debris before washing, not after.

One simple rule: *if it needs a tall ladder, call us.*

Ground-floor windows and a single-story patio are fine weekend projects. Second- and third-story glass, steep or high gutters, and roofs are where most falls happen, and where a crew with water-fed poles and proper ladders gets better results in a fraction of the time.

Window Cleaning

Interior and exterior glass, hand-scrubbed and squeegeed. Screens, frames, and sills detailed.

STARTING AT \$199

Gutter Cleaning

Debris removed by hand, gutters and downspouts flushed, and a check for problem spots.

STARTING AT \$150

Pressure & Soft Washing

Driveways, walkways, patios, siding, and decks. The right method for each surface.

STARTING AT \$249

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Tell us about your home and we'll reply the same day with a price. No obligation.

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